

Non-Communicable Disease Prevalence in Zambia: Diabetes and Obesity

Summary by Joanna Imasiku

Introduction

Over the past two decades, Zambia has witnessed a rise in the prevalence of Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs). NCDs, also known as chronic diseases, are not mainly caused by acute infection, they tend to be the result of a combination of genetic, physiological, environmental and behavioral factors. NCDs result in long-term health consequences and often create a need for long-term treatment and care.

Overview

This summary focuses on the prevalence rates of Diabetes and Obesity in Zambia from the year 1990 to 2022. Both show an increase in prevalence rates over the years, with notable variations between genders and ages.

Diabetes

Diabetes is a chronic disease that occurs either when the pancreas does not produce enough insulin or when the body cannot effectively use the insulin it produces.

The prevalence rates used were age-standardized rates, to eliminate the influence of varying age distributions, and crude rates, which represent the total proportion of the population suffering from diabetes. From 1990 the prevalence rate of diabetes in the country has increased slightly exponentially. Females over the years generally have a higher prevalence rate than males.

The treatment coverage which is the percentage of people aged over 30 years with diabetes who are currently using glucose-lowering medication increased steadily from the year 1990 to 2004 and then begun to drop in the year 2005. Over the entire period a greater proportion of males have been receiving treatment compared to females.

Obesity

Overweight and obesity are defined as abnormal or excessive fat accumulation that presents a risk to health. Obesity is recognized by the World Health Organization (WHO) and major health organizations as a chronic disease and a primary, modifiable risk factor for the development of major NCDs.

Adults in this analysis are aged 18 years and older and children and adolescents comprise the complement of the adult population. The adult population has a higher prevalence of obese and overweight individuals. Females have a higher prevalence of obese and overweight individuals across all age groups except for obese children and adolescents where males have a higher prevalence rate.

Limitations

Not all the available data is nationally representative. Some studies only measured Fasting Plasma Glucose (FPG) or only measured glycated hemoglobin (HbA1c) for the prevalence of diabetes.

Conclusion

The rise in prevalence rates calls for further investigations on the impact NCDs pose on Zambia's health sector.